style system of advertising house swaps. Likewise *Plaff* poked fun at the bureaucracies and material hardships of everyday life.

While the above-mentioned films incorporated critiques of contemporary realities, the cultural and political establishment raised no objections. The reception of *Alicia en el pueblo de Maravillas – Alice in Wondertown* – when it was first shown in 1989 was quite different. *Alicia* was another comedy that parodied Cuba's bureaucracies and inefficiencies. But in the political and economic context of the collapse of the Soviet bloc and the vast uncertainty facing Cuba – *Miami Herald* columnist Andrés Oppenheimer was predicting "Castro's final hour" – the ax came down on *Alicia*. Only a few days after the film was released, and won an award at the Berlin Film Festival, it was banned in Cuba. Even more dramatically, the Cuban Film Institute was informed that it would become one of the many victims of the economic crisis, and be merged with the film and television division of the Armed Forces. The Institute saw this as a death blow to the autonomy and creativity of the country's entire film industry.

After loud and intense protest, the government backed down – partially. The Institute was restored, but its head, García Espinosa, was replaced with his predecessor, Alfredo Guevara. And *Alicia* remained banned, a victim as much of the historical moment in which it appeared as of the longstanding contradiction between the liberatory and the repressive strains in Cuban cultural policy.

Sergio Giral described *María Antonia*, released in 1990 and the last film he made on the island, as his best work. Like his earlier historical films, *María Antonia* delved into Afro-Cuban culture – the Yoruba-based *santería* – and harsh realities of poverty and racism. Although based on a 1968 play and set in the 1950s, it clearly critiqued contemporary realities as well, especially in the final scene where the poverty and racial inequalities of the past are transposed into the present.

Although Giral subsequently left Cuba for Miami, other historic and new directors continued to push Cuba's film industry in new directions in the 1990s, with films like Gutiérrez Alea's *Strawberry and Chocolate* and *Guatnanamera* (1995) and Fernando Pérez's *La vida es silbar* (*Life is to Whistle*, 1998) enjoying acclaim both on the island and abroad. The